7. China Creates Its Own Buddhist Universe

In the first century CE , when Buddhism began to influence Chinese culture, it brought with it several new concepts, beliefs, practices and patterns of behaviour. As the scholar John Kieschnick writes in his deeply researched book *The Impact of Buddhism on Chinese Material Culture*, [1] these included a new pantheon of deities, the practice of making offerings to their images, rituals of consecration, ‘belief in incarnation and the doctrine of karma . . . forms of seated meditation’, and ‘even the new gesture of palms pressed together’ in veneration. Kieschnick goes on to say that these Buddhist practices continue to ‘hold a prominent place in Chinese material culture’.

In this sense, Indian influence on China is more pervasive, more deeply ingrained and often more unsettling to the Chinese than is acknowledged. It is unsettling because acknowledging its impact on virtually all aspects of Chinese culture contradicts an equally pervasive notion China has of being the central source of civilizational excellence. There is a similarly pervasive belief among Indians of the superiority of Indian civilization and a consequent disinterest in China and Chinese culture, and therefore an ignorance of the deeper affinities that bind the two civilizational states together.

This was not always so. During the first millennium, Chinese Buddhist monks and scholars acknowledged that the India of the time represented a superior culture and was an intellectual powerhouse, a teacher that China could learn from. The efforts of the Chinese monks who visited India during the millennium and the steady stream of Indian Buddhist monks and translators who came to preach in China and set up various monastic centres and temples were aimed at creating in China a Buddhist realm based on Indian design, a replica of the sacred land. The immense body of Chinese translations of the Buddhist scriptures brought a new vocabulary, new expressions and metaphors which, over time, became embedded in Chinese colloquial language, Chinese literature and conceptual thought.